W45

DECODE UPSC with Mounika

November 1st Week Current Affairs 2026

Reading script · English + తెలుగు · 15 topics · Sunday 8 November, 6 PM

Script

What if I told you that one week changed the Agnipath scheme, your Deepavali crackers, the rights of every arrested person, and even the price of cancer medicines?

ఇవన్నీ ఈ ఒక్క వారంలో జరిగాయి.

I am Mounika, and today we will decode the 15 strongest stories of November’s first week, with the static fact behind each one and the exact trap UPSC can set.

మన ప్రయాణం start చేద్దాం.

Here is our map for today: five stories on law and welfare, four on the economy, three on defence, one from the world, and two important days, plus one alert for Telugu aspirants at the end.

1 · Agnipath

Let us start with the story every defence aspirant is searching for: has the Agnipath scheme been scrapped?

Agnipath began in June 2022, recruiting young people between 17 and a half and 21 years of age as Agniveers for four years, and only about one in four were to stay on as regular soldiers. This week the Union Cabinet approved a big change: about three in four Agniveers will get two more years of service, with higher pay and a bigger Seva Nidhi exit package, and a pathway to regular enrolment for those who are willing and meet the selection criteria.

Prelims trap: the scheme has not been scrapped; it has been modified, and entry is still through the four-year Agniveer route.

ఇది గుర్తుపెట్టుకోండి.

And for Mains, think of the trade-off: a younger army on one side, and experience and training costs on the other.

2 · Green crackers

And with Deepavali here, our second story asks: can the Supreme Court decide how you celebrate a festival?

On November 2, the Supreme Court allowed only certified green crackers in Delhi and the National Capital Region, on the 7th and 8th, from 6 to 7 in the morning and 8 to 10 at night, and never within 300 metres of hospitals, schools and silence zones. Why can a court do this? Because the freedom of religion under Article 25 is subject to public health, and the right to life under Article 21 includes clean air. The Court said pollution defeats the very purpose of the festival.

Now the trap. Green crackers were designed by the National Environmental Engineering Research Institute in Nagpur, and they contain no barium nitrate. But the institute only designs the formula; the Petroleum and Explosives Safety Organisation, under the Commerce Ministry, licenses the makers under the

Explosives Act of 1884.

3 · Two-child rule

Story three is very close to home for us in the Telugu states: can having a third child stop you from contesting a panchayat election?

This week the Supreme Court said laws that disqualify people with more than two children from panchayat elections have lost relevance, and sent its 2003 Javed judgment, which upheld such a law in Haryana, to a larger bench. The reason is data: India’s total fertility rate has fallen from about 3 to 1.9, below the replacement level of 2.1. And who makes these rules? Article 243F lets each state’s law decide panchayat disqualifications, while the Court now asks whether punishing family size hurts reproductive choice under Article 21.

Telugu states lens: Andhra Pradesh had this rule since 1994 and scrapped it in 2024, and Telangana removed it for rural bodies in 2026. But remember the trap: the Supreme Court has not struck the rule down; it only referred the question to a larger bench.

4 · Arrest or detention?

Story four protects every one of us: when exactly does the 24-hour clock start after the police pick you up?

Article 22, clause 2, says an arrested person must be produced before the nearest magistrate within 24 hours, leaving out only the travel time. In a drug case from Tripura, the police held four people for searches and paperwork, and recorded the arrest much later. On November 5, the Supreme Court said there is no difference between detention and arrest here: the clock starts the moment your liberty is curtailed, and it ordered the four released. It also overruled the Orissa, Kerala and Madras High Courts, which had allowed such time to be left out.

Prelims trap: the 24 hours run from detention, not from the time the arrest is written down, and the only time excluded is the journey to the magistrate. Also remember, Article 22, clause 3, says these safeguards do not apply to an enemy alien or to a person held under preventive detention.

5 · Fast-track special courts

Story five is about speedy justice for women and children.

The Cabinet extended the fast-track special courts scheme till March 2031, with about ₹3,788 crore, and raised the number of courts from 779 to 850. These courts hear rape cases and cases under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act. The scheme began in 2019, after the Criminal Law Amendment Act of 2018. Prelims trap: it is a centrally sponsored scheme, so the states share the cost, and the Centre’s part comes from the Nirbhaya Fund.

Bridge (on camera)

Five stories done, ten to go.

మీరు ఇక్కడ వరకు ఉంటే, మీరు serious aspirant!

Now let us move from rights and courts to villages, power and money.

6 · Rural jobs law

Story six touches every village: what can a worker do if the work or the wages never come?

From July 1, the Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission, Gramin, Act replaced the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act, and raised the guarantee from 100 to 125 days of work. This week the Rural Development Ministry notified its grievance rules: a complaint can be filed in person, by post, online or on a helpline, and it must be enquired into within 7 working days and solved within 15, at Gram Panchayat, Block and District level.

Prelims trap: the Centre no longer pays all the wages; the cost is now shared 60 to 40 with the states, and 90 to 10 for Himalayan and north-eastern states. Telugu states lens: united Andhra Pradesh pioneered social audits of this programme, with its own audit society from 2009.

7 · Storing electricity

Story seven answers a simple question: what happens to solar power after sunset?

The Cabinet approved ₹14,500 crore of viability gap funding to build 92 gigawatt-hours of grid-scale storage: 60 from pumped storage, 30 from batteries and 2 from new technologies. Viability gap funding means the government pays part of the cost, so that a project which is useful but not yet profitable becomes viable.

Pumped storage is like a giant water battery: you pump water uphill when power is cheap, and let it fall through turbines when it is needed. Prelims trap: the biggest share here is pumped storage, not batteries.

8 · Critical minerals

Story eight follows the battery inside your phone: where does its lithium get processed?

Lithium and nickel are critical minerals for batteries and electric vehicles, but processing them is concentrated in a few countries. So the Cabinet approved a ₹2,814 crore scheme that pays 30 per cent of the capital cost of four processing plants in India, two for lithium and two for nickel, over five years. Notice the chain: our storage story needs batteries, and batteries need processed minerals.

Prelims trap: this scheme is about processing, not mining or recycling. Recycling has its own ₹1,500 crore scheme from 2025.

9 · VISTAR

Story nine is about the numbers behind every policy: how does India count its shops and factories?

The Cabinet approved VISTAR, a scheme of about ₹4,371 crore over five years, to modernise India’s statistical system with digital tools and artificial intelligence. It will run 59 surveys and the 8th Economic Census, which counts every non-farm establishment and its workers. Prelims trap: the Economic Census is run by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, while the Population Census is run by the Registrar General and Census Commissioner under the Home Ministry.

10 · New aviation rules

Story ten: why was India still flying under rules written in 1937?

The Civil Aviation Ministry notified the Bharatiya Vayuyan Niyam, 2026, which replace the colonial-era Aircraft Rules of 1937 from January 1, 2027. They cover aircraft registration, safety, licences and airports, and they let the government step in on air fares in extraordinary situations. Prelims trap: the Niyam are the rules; the parent law is the Bharatiya Vayuyan Adhiniyam of 2024, which replaced the Aircraft Act of 1934.

Bridge (on camera)

Ten done!

ఇప్పుడు defence and ప్రపంచం వైపు చూద్దాం.

11 · Pralay missile

Story eleven is a missile with a dramatic name: Pralay.

On November 5, the Defence Research and Development Organisation flight-tested Pralay from Doctor A P J Abdul Kalam Island off Odisha. Pralay is a quasi-ballistic missile, which means it can change its path in flight, so it is harder to intercept. Prelims trap: Agni and Prithvi are ballistic missiles, while BrahMos is a cruise missile built with Russia, so do not mix up the families.

12 · Malabar 2026

From land to sea: our twelfth story is Exercise Malabar.

Malabar 2026 is being held off Honshu in Japan from the 5th to the 12th of November, with the navies of India, the United States, Japan and Australia, the same four countries that form the Quad. India has sent the frigate Indian Naval Ship Sahyadri.

Prelims trap: Malabar began in 1992 as a two-nation exercise between India and the United States; Japan became a permanent member in 2015, and Australia rejoined in 2020.

13 · America’s midterm elections

Story thirteen is the biggest election story of the week, from the United States.

In America’s midterm elections, the Democrats won control of the House of Representatives, and reports say they may control the Senate too, though the final count is still pending. Remember the structure: the House has 435 members elected every two years, while the Senate has 100 members with six-year terms, and about a third face election every two years. They are called midterms because they fall halfway through the President’s four-year term.

Now connect it to India, because this is a favourite trap. Our Rajya Sabha works like the American Senate: members serve six years and about one third retire every two years, so the Rajya Sabha is a permanent house that is never dissolved. The Lok Sabha, like the House of Representatives, is directly elected, but for five years, not two.

14 · Day against bullying at school

Now two important days. Story fourteen was on November 5.

The International Day against Violence and Bullying at School, including Cyberbullying, is held on the first Thursday of November. It was declared by the member states of the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization in 2019 and first observed in 2020, and one in three students worldwide has been bullied in the past month. Prelims trap: India’s National Commission for Protection of Child Rights is a statutory body under a 2005 Act, not a constitutional one.

15 · Cancer Awareness Day and cheaper cancer medicines

And story fifteen: November 7 is National Cancer Awareness Day, and this year it comes with good news on medicine prices.

The day falls on Marie Curie’s birthday, and India has marked it since 2014. From November 9, the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority caps the trade margin on 137 anti-cancer medicines at 30 per cent, using paragraph 19 of the Drugs Prices Control Order of 2013, so some prices may fall by up to 70 per cent.

Two traps here. Marie Curie won two Nobel Prizes in two different sciences, Physics in 1903 and Chemistry in 1911. And the pricing authority sits under the Department of Pharmaceuticals in the Chemicals and Fertilizers Ministry, not under the Health Ministry.

Alert

One alert for Telugu aspirants: Andhra Pradesh has announced its District Selection Committee teacher recruitment for about 2,721 posts, with applications reported from November 11. Please check the official website for exact details.

Quiz

Now, your quick-fire question. How many of these four statements are correct? Pause the video and answer.

(stay silent for 7 seconds)

The answer is only two: statements two and three. Agnipath has been modified, not scrapped, and the Economic Census is run by the Statistics Ministry. How many did you get right?

Comment చేయండి!

Mains practice

And for Mains, here is this week’s one writing question: is the protection of Article 22 real only if the 24-hour clock runs from the moment liberty is curtailed? Write 150 words in 7 minutes, and

మీ answer comments లో రాయండి.

All 15 practice MCQs, with answers, are in the practice sheet linked in the description.

Close (on camera)

That was November’s first week: 15 stories, 15 traps. If this helped, share it with one friend who is preparing with you, and subscribe for every Sunday’s class.

అందరికీ దీపావళి శుభాకాంక్షలు, green గా జరుపుకుందాం!